

AFP

POWER PUSHBACK A Congress protest in Srinagar demands immediate restoration of statehood, Jul. 19

act. Pressure had been building on Omar for having failed to prevent a coup from above: a capture of powers in general administration and other departments by Raj Bhawan. Looming large was the risk of losing relevance as a ruling party and among his flock, turning into a de facto lame-duck government, stuck in a statutory limbo that reduced Delhi to a quasi-state.

THE SOFT PATH

Back in the saddle in October 2024, the CM has till now been walking a tightrope with New Delhi so as to enable a smooth, consensual delivery of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's promise to return J&K to full statehood. He extended a friendly hand on most fronts, eschewing a direct faceoff even on flashpoints like the Waqf Amendment Bill, 2025. He treaded cautiously in his run-ins with Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha.

Within the National Conference (NC), he dodged exhortations to go into protest mode and preferred to pedal softly. Right up to subtly nudging Modi about his commitment during the Sonamarg tunnel inaugural, the CM did all he could to get his ghee with a straight finger.

With all that affability going waste, the tone is getting dialled up. "Some people have the misunderstanding that we don't talk in a high-pitched voice. We don't issue threats, or engage in *gundagardi* [hooliganism]," Omar said on July 15. That was a signal, first of all, to his own restive flock of NC legislators who had preferred confrontation from the start. What triggered this turn towards the rockier path? Pressure tactics—deployed to express anger over his detention just ahead of the monsoon session of Parliament.

Takeaways

- **Omar takes a louder stance on statehood, departing from his tack of soft persuasion**
- **His ally Congress makes a unilateral push which Omar feels has upset his apple cart**

There's also an unforeseen spurt of activism from INDIA ally Congress: protests over statehood in Srinagar and Jammu, followed by a dharna at Delhi's Jantar Mantar. Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi also wrote to the PM on July 16, urging him to redeem his promise during the monsoon session.

Caught off-guard, the NC now suggests the Congress's unilateral push may be counter-productive, aborting what may have come about naturally. Since the Modi regime is not known to relent easily on Opposition demands, it may have foreclosed an ajar door, in this view. Others speculate that New Delhi may have already opted to move on statehood in some way, and an announcement was imminent.

INTRIGUE IN PARADISE

If that gets subverted into a step that does not favour Kashmir, it's being insinuated that having precisely such an effect—to frustrate Omar's sugar-coated diplomacy just when it could have borne fruit—is the very intention of the Congress. Outwardly, the NC is feigning a softer kind of hurt. "We read about it in newspapers. No one reached out to us. Even during the recent INDIA meeting, there was no mention of these things. Had they informed us, we would have joined," Omar says. "We've been struggling for statehood, overtly and covertly. By moving without consulting us, the Congress has poured water on our efforts," an NC senior told INDIA TODAY. Ghulam Ahmad Mir, AICC general secretary and MLA, is taunting in his counter: "What's stopping them from launching protests or joining us? They should call a special assembly session. We'll support it."

Relations between the Congress and NC—or Rahul and Omar—form a mystery wrapped within the statehood riddle. The two fought the 2024 assembly election together, and won a famous victory against the BJP. But the Congress didn't join the government: the unkind version is it wished to keep its slate 'clean' ahead of the Haryana and Maharashtra polls. Now, the rising mutual tension has become an unlikely obstacle in a common objective. ■